



Dirac and Schrodinger What are Dirac and Schrodinger?

Dirac is a new video file format and Shrodinger the equivalent video codec. The codec version 1.0 was recently released. The source code for the codec can be downloaded from diracvideo.org for integration into video players.

Why the hype?

The file format should be very versatile, and capable of handling highly compressed web video, through HD quality, up to almost lossless broadcast quality.

Where do Dirac and Schrodinger stand?

In competition to the ever increasing number of video formats. However, it is the versatility mentioned above that is intended to be the key point. The codec has now been integrated into the latest version of the popular VLC player, and will no doubt be adopted by others soon.

Who is in charge?

The BBC research department developed the file format and the codec. The BBC has, however, refused to accept responsibility for the wave function collapse of any cast involved.

How does it work?

The algorithm is wavelet based, and works on Rate-Distortion Optimisation (RDO) principles. This attempts to balance the inevitable trade-off between better compression and distortion in the decompressed images, and was originally developed on the basis of MPEG-2. Full documentation is available from the BBC.

DREAM FOR GOOD

Google's Wireless Hopes

According to recent reports it was confirmed that Internet search Giant Google has filed a patent with the US Patent office for its vision of Wireless network for mobile phones. Just like every other product from Google the very idea is quite revolutionary.

According to Google's vision of an open wireless network, smart phones are not tied or locked to any particular network or service provider, and smart phones and wireless devices will be able to migrate to better and stronger networks as per their needs. They will also be able to choose a particular network or service provider, based on the pricing it is offering.

The idea is to make devices smart so that they can choose between networks based on their signal strength. So if you have better connectivity to Network A at office, the device will automatically latch on to it. At home, however, if you have equal strength for Network B and Network C, the phone will choose a network based on what you are doing. So if you're making calls, it might use Network B, which offers lower voice calling rates. However, if it's Web surfing that you're doing, and Network C is cheaper for data connections, the device will automatically switch to C, and save you some hard earned money. Your device might also identify a low cost WiMax or Wi-Fi provider in the

area, and route all your Net traffic through one of those.

The idea for this comes from the fact that you have to pay penalties for breaking your contract with a mobile service provider, but you do no such thing when using your laptop to latch onto any available wireless service. Today, even in India, we can sit at famous coffee outlets, or restaurants, and log on using the wireless access provided to us; so why not do the same for your mobile phone? That's what Google wants to bring to us.

Though Google seems to have the right idea, it's doubtful that network service providers will ever allow this to happen.

It's not like this can happen overnight anyway, because even hardware manufacturers have to include this functionality in their devices, and this is easier said than done.

So although this initiative might be a long way off, we think it's a step in the right direction. As you wait for number portability to become a reality in India, you can add Google's Open Wireless plans to your list of services and technologies to pray for. Seriously, every night, before you sleep. Open Wireless. Remember that.

PUSHING CF LIMITS

World Record Compact Flash Cards

Photography enthusiasts around the world have reason to celebrate as Pretec flew past its own record for the highest capacity compact

flash card ever made. The record stood at 48 GB, but the new ones have a storage capacities of 64 GB and 100 GB. These cards are used by enthusiast and professional cameras around the world.

Size is not the only record that Pretec has a tendency of breaking. They also break records in the data transfer speeds of the cards. The 64 GB and 100 GB cards transfer at speeds of 32 Mbps, whereas the lower capacity 32 GB and the 48 GB cards transfer data at the speeds of 50 Mbps. The 32 GB cards with the fast data transfer speeds cost more than the 64 GB cards with the slower data transfer speeds. The cards are housed in a metal casing that are resistant to impact and shock — making the cards ten times more resistant than ordinary cards.

The cards are aimed at cameras that handle high resolution images and large chunks of video data. A lot of videographers and photographers in the industry work with uncompressed data, which makes these cards ideal. Furthermore, the four of the 64 GB cards can be re-configured into an array to make a 256 GB SATA or IDE SSD, with another world record for the smallest IDE SSD to have such a storage capacity at 2.5 inches.

The 32 GB card is priced at \$630, and the 64GB card is priced at \$399. The 48 GB and 100 GB cards will be available at the end of the year. ■

